

The first 72 hours after a parent dies

Only what protects people, animals, property and the paper trail. Everything else can wait, and most of it should.

- ☐ **Choose a funeral home and get the legal pronouncement of death.**
They file the death certificate and usually notify Social Security. Ask them to confirm both.
- ☐ **Order 10 to 15 certified death certificates.**
Banks, insurers, brokerages, the DMV and the court each want one, and many keep it. Reordering later costs weeks.
- ☐ **Make sure dependents and pets are cared for.**
Pets are the most-forgotten item on every executor list. Go to the house.
- ☐ **Secure the home.** Lock it, collect spare keys, bring in the mail, set the thermostat.
Empty houses with an obituary in the paper get burgled. Keep the address and the service time out of the notice.
- ☐ **Find the original will and any trust papers.** Desk, safe, freezer, file cabinet, the attorney, the safe-deposit box.
Many states require the original to be filed with the court within 30 days.
- ☐ **Throw nothing away.** Not the mail, not the junk drawer, not the shoebox.
The tax return in that pile lists every bank and brokerage you will need to find.
- ☐ **Check for a prepaid funeral plan or burial insurance before paying anything.**
It is common and often forgotten. Keep every receipt; the estate reimburses reasonable funeral costs.
- ☐ **Start one folder and one notebook.** Every call, every name, every date.
You will speak to forty people this month and remember none of them.
- ☐ **Ask one person to handle the phone tree.**
You cannot field every call and also do this job.
- ☐ **If your parent was a veteran, tell the funeral home.**
Burial benefits, a flag, possibly a national cemetery plot. They know the forms.

Do not, this week: pay any bill from your own money · close bank accounts · cancel the phone (it holds the security codes for every account) · give anyone the car, the ring or "their share" · spend any Social Security or pension deposit that arrived after the death (it will be clawed back) · sign anything a lawyer or collector puts in front of you.

DEATH CERTIFICATES ORDERED

HOW MANY _____

FROM _____

DATE _____

FIRST CALLS

FUNERAL HOME _____

INSURER (HOME) _____

WHO HAS THE KEYS _____

What comes next. Week one is securing and locating. Weeks two to four are finding out whether you need probate and getting yourself legally appointed. Days 30 to 90 are where the deadlines live. *The First 90 Days: An Executor's Working Notebook* walks through all of it in order, with the phone scripts, letters and trackers. theexecutorsdesk.com